

Chapter 69-5

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Xu Qingzhu was quite deeply touched by Liang Shi's words.

The train of thought that had already entered a dead end seemed to suddenly open up in that instant, then she let this matter pass.

Early the next morning, Xu Qingzhu deliberately set an earlier alarm, planning to make breakfast after getting up. But when she came downstairs, Liang Shi was already in the kitchen.

Xu Qingzhu was helpless, yet teased: "Teacher Liang, you're so competitive¹."

Liang Shi: "?"

"I just woke up early." Liang Shi explained: "It just rained, the air outside is super fresh."

"You went for a walk?"

"Yes."

Xu Qingzhu was amazed: "Teacher Liang, your routine is so elderly."

Liang Shi: "....."

For a moment, she didn't know if this was a compliment.

Liang Shi made congee in the morning and also asked Xu Qingzhu if, after eating such spicy food last night, her stomach felt uncomfortable.

As a result, Xu Qingzhu said she was perfectly fine and even had a good dream.

Liang Shi rubbed her somewhat uncomfortable stomach and admitted with slight difficulty: "Then I might indeed be entering the elderly ranks."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

When Xu Qingzhu finished drinking her congee and went to clear the table, she patted Liang Shi's shoulder: "Teacher Liang, exercise well."

Liang Shi: "....."

Early in the morning, Liang Shi felt like she'd been subjected to passive-aggressive remarks².

However, this also indicated from another angle that Xu Qingzhu's emotions had completely adjusted.

She finally felt a bit more at ease.

It wasn't in vain that she gave up this mission!

But fortunately, this afternoon she could complete one side mission.

And this week she could arrange to go on a trip with Xu Qingzhu to complete the second side mission.

While Liang Shi was still calculating her missions, Xu Qingzhu had already arrived at the company.

The Design Department urgently needed fresh blood, so they posted job openings.

Today was the day for second-round interviews after one round of screening.

Xu Qingzhu went directly to the Human Resources Department. There was a dedicated office for conducting recruitment.

The first round of screening had already eliminated most unqualified candidates. The second round had eight people left, from which they needed to select four to enter the Design Department—quite a high ratio.

Those who could enter the second round of interviews were all relatively outstanding, whether looking at their graduating institutions or past design works—all were quite good.

When Xu Qingzhu saw a work she couldn't make up her mind about, she called Zhou Yian over.

Zhou Yian was quite surprised. She had originally thought that after the autumn new product launch, she would become an invisible person in the entire department and had already been considering resignation.

But Xu Qingzhu very seriously asked for her opinion, having her judge this work's completion level.

Zhou Yian wasn't very serious at first, responding quite perfunctorily with a few sentences. But Xu Qingzhu summarized her opinions and wrote them in her notebook, then handed her several more pieces.

After noticing her perfunctory attitude, Xu Qingzhu spoke to her seriously and earnestly: "Designer Zhou, please bring out your professional standards. Don't make me feel that RT's rising design star is nothing more than this. Moreover, for these newcomers, this may be an interview that decides their career fate—it concerns eight people. Please be sure to be serious and then more serious."

She used the formal "you³."

Zhou Yian suddenly felt her ears heat up. From the side, she glanced at Xu Qingzhu several more times and found that she was very seriously reading the interview candidates' materials. So she also put away that casual attitude.

Among the interview candidates, Xu Qingzhu saw a familiar person. When she called out the name, her tone carried a few notes of delight: "Su Meiqi."

Hearing this name, Zhou Yian also raised her head, frowning slightly, asking Xu Qingzhu for the materials: "Give me her resume."

Xu Qingzhu handed it to her: "You know her?"

"Maybe." Zhou Yian wasn't too certain either.

But the instant Su Meiqi walked in, she was certain.

Su Meiqi first saw Xu Qingzhu: "Sister Xu?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "What a coincidence."

Su Meiqi was surprised: "It is quite a coincidence. Why are you at this company?"

Zhou Yian, who hadn't said much since arriving, suddenly spoke: "This is her family's company. What should be asked now is, why are you appearing at this company?"

Su Meiqi: ".....I'm here for an interview."

She turned her head to look, and her expression changed drastically: "Zhou.....Zhou Yian?"

"It's me." Zhou Yian twirled a pen in her hand. "Are you here to gather intelligence for your family's company?"

"No!" Su Meiqi immediately retorted, glaring at her indignantly: "I'm here to work properly."

"Then why aren't you working at your family's company?" Zhou Yian asked her.

Su Meiqi: ".....I'd be treated differently, elder sister⁴!"

Xu Qingzhu looked confused: "You two know each other?"

Zhou Yian nodded, directly revealing Su Meiqi's identity: "The heiress of Haiwei Jewelry, a chuunibyou⁵ girl who designs all sorts of strange things all day long—Su Meiqi."

Su Meiqi's eyes widened: "Elder sister, you can insult me, but you can't insult the things I design."

Zhou Yian seemed to think of something, turning her head to look at Xu Qingzhu. After thinking for a moment, she said: "She has another identity—I just don't know if you're willing to listen."

Xu Qingzhu's intuition told her this should be related to herself. She pressed her lips together: "What?"

Zhou Yian's gaze swept over her, then over Su Meiqi, saying in a low voice: "She has a famous designer aunt named Su Yao."

"Hey!" Su Meiqi gritted her teeth, wishing she could go up and hit Zhou Yian, huffing indignantly: "My aunt is at least half your teacher! And you're selling me out like this?"

Footnotes:

¹ Competitive (卷) - Internet slang derived from "involution" (内卷), referring to excessive competition or overachievement. Here used playfully to tease someone for working too hard or being overly diligent.

² Passive-aggressive remarks (陰陽怪氣) - Literally "yin-yang strange energy," a Chinese expression describing sarcastic, mocking, or passive-aggressive comments that seem polite on the surface but carry negative undertones.

³ Formal "you" (您) - In Chinese, 您 (nín) is a respectful form of "you" used to show deference or maintain professional distance, as opposed to the casual 你 (nǐ). Its use here signals Xu Qingzhu's serious, professional tone.

⁴ Elder sister (姐姐) - Used here as a term of exasperation or pleading, similar to saying "come on!" or addressing someone older/senior to you. Not indicating an actual familial relationship.

⁵ Chuunibyou (中二少女) - Literally "second-year middle school girl," a term borrowed from Japanese describing someone (typically adolescent or young adult) who acts immature, has grandiose delusions, or engages in embarrassing behavior while thinking they're cool or special. Often translated as "eighth-grader syndrome."